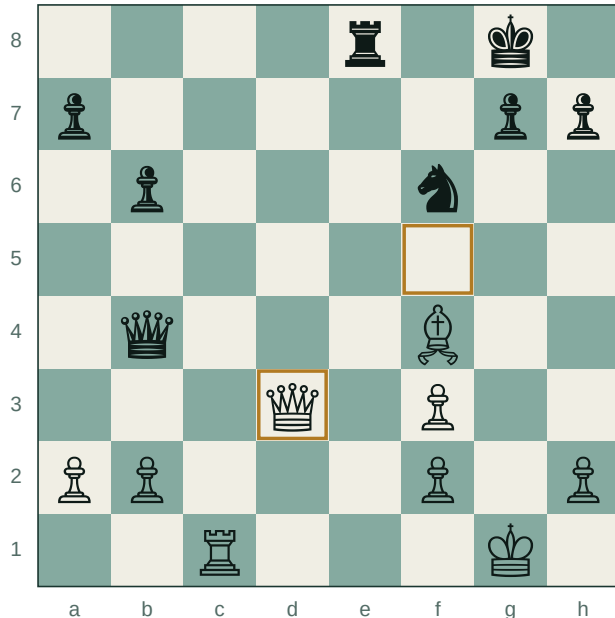


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 24

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 24.Qd3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

24...Qxf4 25. Qc4+ Qxc4

24...Qxf4 The queen captures the bishop on f4. Recorded reply: **25.Qc4+**.

25...Qxc4 The queen captures the queen on c4.

At the end, nominal material is White 10 / Black 21 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +12. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +12:** the balance goes from -1 to +11. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: bishop on f4 and queen on d3. Check for tactical protection.